

Key Takeaways: Supporting Families in an Age of Competing Demands

The May 2016 Monthly Network Meeting focused on how various projects support state systems building partnerships with families of individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities. The information included SELN-sponsored online events and information gathering, as well as work being done through the Rehabilitation Research and Training Center and the National Association of Developmental Disability Directors Supporting Families Community of Practice.

SELN Hub members can navigate to the Monthly Network Meeting groups page for materials and the meeting recording. Contact Sheila Johnson at Sheila.johnson@umb.edu to learn more about registering for www.SELNHub.org.

States should consider how they are making the shift from having families just being present to being partners fully engaged in the development of policy and promotion of “employment in the general workforce” or “community-based employment.” The following actions can help states improve in this effort:

- Reach out to families prior to middle and high school. Early and continuous access to support through the lifespan is effective in helping families understand what is available, from whom, and for how long.
- Communicate consistently to everyone the benefits of tapping into the power of families, and the value of forming an alliance with them to advance the system’s goals and mission. Learn when families want to be involved, how they wish to participate (e.g., in person, online, via email), and their desired frequency of involvement.
- As early as possible, establish competitive, integrated employment as the expectation. Prepare the family and individual for future planning toward a career pathway.
- Use a wide array of strategies to reach families and share information. Traditional methods, such as training and peer-to-peer mentoring, are important, but also include newer platforms such as social media.
- Make planning tools available that are person-centered, flexible, family-friendly, and accessible.
- Measure performance to monitor success, and use data to make improvements in supporting and engaging families.



**State Employment
Leadership Network**

www.selnhub.org

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.



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